

Geographic Terms

Word Roots

Lesson 3.05.05 | Week 14 | Great Map Room

SS.3.G.1.3 | SS.3.G.1.4 | SS.3.G.2.1

*A rolling cabinet appears outside the World Map Hall with a note:
"For the Word Roots Collection -- please deliver to the World Geography Curators."*

CHAT FRAME

"The volunteer picks up a card that says peninsula and squints. 'Pen-in-su-la. Is that even English?'"

"The head curator smiles. 'It's Latin. Pen means almost and insula means island. A peninsula is almost an island -- land surrounded by water on three sides.'"

"The volunteer's eyes go wide. 'So the word actually tells you what it looks like?'"

CURATOR'S QUESTION

How do Latin and Greek word roots help us understand what geographic terms really mean?

VIRTUE SPOTLIGHT -- HONESTY

Honest thinkers don't just guess -- they look carefully and tell the truth about what they find. Today, you'll be honest about what word roots actually tell us. Some roots might surprise you, and that's a good thing. The best curators share what's real, not what's easy.

Your Role: World Geography Curator -- building the Word Roots Collection

Today's Path

THINKING MOVE: NOTICE > NAME > NARRATE

ABC

Break apart geographic terms to find their Latin and Greek roots.

MAP

Use word roots to figure out what a geographic term describes.

PEN

Write a root-based explanation for a geographic term.

What Are Word Roots?

NOTICE

Many geographic terms come from Latin and Greek.

If you know the root, you can figure out what a word means -- even if you've never seen it before.

People didn't just make up the word "peninsula" because it sounded nice. They put two Latin pieces together:

paene (almost) + insula (island)

The word itself is a description!

INSERT IMAGE

Diagram showing 'peninsula' split into 'paene' (almost) + 'insula' (island) with arrows pointing to a peninsula shape

Word Root Cards

NAME _____

geo-

Greek -- means "earth"

geography -- writing about the earth

geology -- study of earth's rocks

geographer -- a person who studies earth

terra-

Latin -- means "land"

terrain -- the surface of the land

territory -- an area of land

terrace -- a flat raised area of land

* If geo- means "earth" and -graphy means "writing," what does geography really mean?

SOCRATIC QUESTIONS - hiding inside "terrain"? What does the land look like?

Word Root Cards

NAME

aqua-

Latin -- means "water"

aquatic -- related to water

aqueduct -- a structure that carries water

aquarium -- a tank of water for animals

pen- / paene-

Latin -- means "almost"

peninsula -- almost an island

(land with water on 3 sides)

penultimate -- almost the last

Root Match Challenge

YOUR TURN

Match each word to its meaning. Use the roots as your clues!

geography

writing about the earth

terrain

land or ground surface

peninsula

almost an island

aquatic

related to water

Think-Pair-Share: Discuss with a partner before we reveal answers!

Root Match -- Answers

geography

geo- (earth) + -graphy (writing)

writing about the earth

terrain

terra- (land)

land or ground surface

peninsula

pen- (almost) + insula (island)

almost an island

aquatic

aqua- (water)

related to water

Source Study: See the Root in Action

NARRATE

INSERT IMAGE

Real photograph of a peninsula (aerial view showing land surrounded by water on three sides), or a Roman aqueduct, or terraced farmland -- source: Library of Congress, Wikimedia Commons, or NASA Earth Observatory. Save as source-3-05-05-root-feature.jpg

QUESTION LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

What do I see?

What kind of place is it? What does the name tell you to expect?

What does it mean?

What root is hiding inside the name? How does it match what you see?

Why does it matter?

Why did the people who named this place choose that root?

Discovery Fact

The word "Arctic" comes from the Greek word arktos, meaning "bear" -- because the northern sky has the constellation Ursa Major, the Great Bear!

THEN AND NOW

Ancient Romans and Greeks named the places they discovered using their own languages. Thousands of years later, we still use those roots.

The word Mediterranean literally means "middle of the land."

Some names never change.

Why Word Roots Matter

EXHIBIT LABEL

Latin and Greek word roots are hidden inside geographic terms. Knowing the root helps you understand -- and explain -- what a term really describes.

When you write a label for the map, you can use roots to explain terms clearly.

OPTI SAYS...

The word "volcano" comes from Vulcan, the Roman god of fire. Even the name tells you what happens there!

Self-Check

Not graded -- just for you!

1

The root geo- means "earth." What does a geographer study?

A. The ocean floor B. The earth and its features C. Outer space

Answer: B -- geo- means earth, so a geographer studies the earth and its features.

2

The root terra- means "land." Which word most likely describes the surface of the land?

A. Terrain B. Aquarium C. Compass

Answer: A -- Terrain contains the root terra- (land). It describes the land's surface.

Self-Check (continued)

3

If pen- means "almost" and insula means "island," what is a peninsula?

- A. A small island far from shore
- B. Land surrounded by water on three sides
- C. A deep ocean trench

Answer: B -- A peninsula is "almost" an island -- land with water on three sides.

4

The root aqua- means "water." An aqueduct is a structure that ____.

- A. Grows crops on dry land
- B. Carries water from one place to another
- C. Measures temperature

Answer: B -- An aqueduct carries water. The aqua- root is your clue.

Error Analysis: Spot the Mistake

YOUR TURN

A student wrote:

"The word terrain comes from the root aqua, which means land. That's why terrain describes the surface of the ground."

SOCRATIC QUESTIONS

- *What is wrong with this explanation?*
- *Which root does terrain actually come from?*
- *How would you fix this to make it honest and accurate?*

Remember: Honest curators share what's real, not what's easy!

Evidence Question 1

ASSIGNMENT PREP

Pick one geographic term from this lesson (geography, terrain, peninsula, or aquatic). What root does it come from, and what does that root mean?

MODEL ANSWER:

"I pick the word peninsula. It comes from the Latin roots pen- (almost) and insula (island). These roots mean that a peninsula is almost an island -- land with water on three sides."

Your turn: Name the word, its root, and the root's meaning.

Evidence Question 2

ASSIGNMENT PREP

Why would it help museum visitors to know the word roots of geographic terms? Give a reason.

THINK ABOUT IT:

Imagine a visitor sees the word "peninsula" on a museum label but doesn't know what it means.

If the label also showed the roots pen- (almost) + insula (island), the visitor could figure it out on their own.

Word roots help visitors understand tricky terms without needing someone to explain every word.

Curator Task: "Did You Know?" Card

ASSIGNMENT

The head curator wants to add "Did You Know?" cards next to tricky terms on the World Map. These cards explain the word root so visitors can see what the term really means.

Pick one geographic term from the Word Roots cabinet. Write a short "Did You Know?" card (3-5 sentences) that explains:

1. The term
2. What root it comes from
3. What that root means
4. How knowing the root helps someone picture the term

CURATOR'S CHRONICLE

Finish this sentence: "In this exhibit, I learned that _____ because _____."

Great Work, World Geography Curator!

COMING NEXT

Opening Night is tomorrow -- and one frame by the entrance is still blank. The head curator says: "Every exhibit starts with an explanation. Visitors need a label that tells them what this whole room is about."

Tomorrow you'll write the most important label in the World Map Hall.